

Refund & Complaint Handling Policy

Owning area: Customer_support

Policy ID: CS-POL-014

Version: 3.2

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Approved by: Director of Customer Operations

Applies to: IronStore EU operating companies and customer-support channels

1. Purpose and Overview

This policy defines how IronStore receives, investigates, and resolves customer complaints and refund requests. It is intended to provide consistent outcomes, protect customer rights, and ensure that cases are recorded accurately for operational and regulatory reporting.

IronStore sells consumer products across Europe, including electronics, home essentials, clothing, outdoor equipment, beauty products, and other categories. Refund eligibility may differ by product type, fulfilment route, payment method, country, and applicable consumer law. Where local law provides a stronger customer right than this policy, the legal requirement takes precedence.

2. Scope

This policy applies to:

- Orders placed through IronStore websites, mobile applications, and approved marketplace channels.
- Customer contacts received by email, web form, live chat, telephone, and social-care channels.
- Refunds for cancelled orders, returns, damaged or faulty goods, failed delivery, duplicate charges, and service errors.
- Complaints about products, delivery, payment, customer service, sellers, or fulfilment partners.
- Cases handled by Customer Support, Payments Operations, Warehouse Operations, and Marketplace Support.

This policy does not replace product-specific safety procedures, payment-provider rules, or country-specific legal guidance.

3. Policy Statement

IronStore will:

- Acknowledge complaints and refund requests promptly.
- Apply the same decision rules to comparable cases.
- Provide clear explanations when a request is declined or only partly approved.
- Record all material actions in the approved case-management system.

- Protect customer data and limit access to staff with a business need.
- Escalate safety, legal, fraud, and executive-risk matters without delay.
- Pay approved refunds to the original payment method unless an approved exception applies.

Customer Support must not promise a refund before eligibility has been checked, except where a published automatic-refund rule clearly applies.

4. Standard Refund Procedure

4.1 Case intake and verification

The agent must locate the order in **ServiceHub**, using the order number, verified email address, or approved marketplace reference.

Before discussing order details or issuing a refund, the agent must verify at least two approved identifiers, such as:

- Customer email address and order number.
- Delivery postcode and product description.
- Payment token suffix and order date.

Agents must not request or record full card numbers, CVV codes, account passwords, or unnecessary identity documents.

The agent records:

- Contact channel and date.
- Customer's stated reason.
- Affected item, quantity, and order line.
- Evidence supplied, including photographs or carrier information.
- Requested outcome and applicable policy reason code.

4.2 Eligibility assessment

The agent checks the following in **ServiceHub** and **OrderCore**:

1. Order status and fulfilment route.
2. Delivery date or confirmed cancellation date.
3. Return-window status.
4. Product category restrictions.
5. Previous refunds, replacements, or related complaints.
6. Payment settlement status and refund capability.

For standard consumer returns, the applicable country return period is shown in the customer's order terms. Unless a longer legal or commercial period applies, unopened and resalable goods are accepted within 30 calendar days of

delivery. Product-specific exceptions include:

- Personalised goods: normally non-returnable unless faulty.
- Sealed hygiene or beauty products: non-returnable after seal removal where permitted by law.
- Digital content: subject to acceptance and commencement rules.
- Large or hazardous goods: collection may be required.
- Marketplace items: the marketplace seller's approved return workflow applies.

A faulty, damaged, incorrect, or materially misdescribed item must not be rejected solely because the standard return window has expired. The agent follows the applicable statutory remedy process and consults **Returns Operations** where the remedy is unclear.

4.3 Evidence and inspection

Evidence should be proportionate to the issue. Agents may request:

- Clear photographs of damaged packaging or product.
- A short video for intermittent faults where practical.
- Carrier damage details or delivery confirmation.
- Serial number or batch information for controlled products.

Do not request evidence that is unsafe, unreasonable, or already available in IronStore systems. For low-value items, the **No-Return Refund Matrix** may permit a refund without physical return.

The current matrix is:

- Up to €25: agent may refund or replace without approval when evidence is sufficient.
- €25.01–€150: team-lead approval is required for a no-return refund unless an automatic rule applies.
- Over €150: Returns Operations or Payments Operations approval is required.
- Any safety-related product: immediate escalation, regardless of value.

4.4 Refund approval and processing

The agent selects the correct reason code and enters the amount in **ServiceHub**. The system performs duplicate-refund and open-dispute checks before submission.

Approval requirements:

- Up to €150: trained agent within documented authority.
- €150.01–€500: Customer Support Team Lead.
- Above €500: Customer Operations Manager and Finance Operations.
- Any goodwill amount above €50: Team Lead approval.
- Any refund outside policy: Customer Operations Manager approval, with rationale recorded.

Refunds are normally returned to the original payment method. Finance Operations handles exceptions such as expired cards, closed accounts, cash-on-delivery payments, or payment-provider limitations.

Expected processing times after approval:

- Card and digital wallet refunds: usually 3–7 business days.
- Bank-transfer refunds: usually 3–5 business days after bank details are validated.
- Marketplace refunds: according to the marketplace settlement timetable.
- Refunds awaiting warehouse inspection: decision within five business days of receipt unless a specialist assessment is required.

The customer must receive a confirmation showing the approved amount, refund method, and expected processing time.

4.5 Partial refunds, replacements, and goodwill

A partial refund may be offered where the customer keeps an item with a minor, documented defect and the solution is lawful and commercially appropriate. The amount must reflect the issue and must not be used to avoid a statutory remedy.

Replacement is preferred when:

- The item is unavailable for immediate refund processing.
- The customer requests a replacement and stock is available.
- Replacement is operationally safer or faster than repair.

Goodwill credits are discretionary and must not be described as a legal entitlement. Agents must not issue goodwill to close a complaint involving safety, discrimination, suspected fraud, or a serious data incident; those cases require escalation.

5. Complaint Handling Procedure

5.1 Definition and acknowledgement

A complaint is any expression of dissatisfaction that requires a response, investigation, or corrective action. The agent creates a **Complaint** case in ServiceHub rather than treating it only as a standard enquiry.

The acknowledgement should include:

- Complaint reference number.
- Summary of the issue as understood.
- Named owner or responsible team.
- Expected next update date.
- Any information still required from the customer.

Target timeframes:

- Acknowledge within one business day.
- Provide a substantive response within five business days.
- Resolve standard complaints within ten business days where practical.
- Notify the customer if an investigation will take longer and provide a revised date.

5.2 Investigation and resolution

The case owner reviews order history, contact notes, warehouse scans, carrier events, payment records, and relevant seller communications. Staff must avoid speculative statements and distinguish confirmed facts from assumptions.

Possible outcomes include:

- Explanation with no further action.
- Refund, replacement, repair, or return arrangement.
- Delivery investigation with the carrier or fulfilment centre.
- Product or seller escalation.
- Process correction and customer apology.
- Formal referral to Legal, Compliance, or Product Safety.

The final response must be clear, respectful, and specific. It should state:

- What was reviewed.
- The decision and reason.
- Any refund or corrective action.
- Expected completion date.
- How the customer may request a review.

5.3 Escalation triggers

Immediate escalation through the **Risk & Escalations queue** is required for:

- Injury, fire, electric shock, contamination, or suspected product safety risk.
- Allegations of discrimination, harassment, or abusive staff conduct.
- Threats of legal action, regulator contact, media exposure, or executive complaint.
- Suspected payment fraud, account takeover, or organised refund abuse.
- Repeated delivery failures affecting multiple customers.
- Requests from law enforcement, regulators, or data-protection authorities.
- Vulnerable-customer concerns requiring specialist support.

Product Safety cases must also be logged in **IncidentTrack** within four hours. Staff must not advise customers to continue using a potentially unsafe product.

5.4 Review and deadlock

If a customer disputes the outcome, the case is reassigned to a Team Lead or Complaints Specialist who was not the original decision-maker where possible. The review should be completed within five business days.

A second review may change the outcome only when new evidence, a policy error, or an exceptional circumstance is identified. Repeated contacts about the same resolved matter may be managed under the **Reasonable Contact Standard**, but genuine new information must always be assessed.

6. Fraud, Abuse, and Chargebacks

Refund abuse indicators may include repeated claims of non-delivery, inconsistent damage evidence, serial-number mismatches, or multiple accounts linked to the same payment instrument. Agents must not accuse customers or disclose fraud-detection rules.

Suspected abuse is referred to **Trust & Payments** using the reason code REFUND-RISK. Legitimate customer cases must continue to receive a timely response while checks are performed.

When a card chargeback is received:

- Payments Operations owns the dispute response.
- Customer Support must not issue a duplicate refund without approval.
- Relevant delivery, refund, and communication evidence must be preserved.
- The case outcome must be linked to the original ServiceHub record.

7. Records, Reporting, and Data Retention

All decisions, approvals, customer communications, and evidence references must be stored in ServiceHub. Attachments containing sensitive information must use the restricted evidence repository, not personal drives or email inboxes.

Customer data is handled according to the **Privacy and Records Retention Standard**. Staff must not export case lists unless approved for a defined operational purpose.

Customer Operations reviews monthly:

- Refund rate by category, seller, country, and reason code.
- Complaint volume and ageing.
- Repeat contacts and reopened cases.
- Approval exceptions and goodwill spend.
- Chargebacks, fraud referrals, and safety incidents.
- Compliance with acknowledgement and resolution targets.

Trends requiring action are assigned to the relevant process owner and tracked in the monthly Customer Experience review.

8. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Customer Support Agents:** Verify identity, assess eligibility, document cases, and communicate decisions.
- **Team Leads:** Approve defined refunds, review escalations, coach agents, and monitor ageing.
- **Complaints Specialists:** Own formal complaints and independent reviews.
- **Returns Operations:** Assess returned goods, faults, collections, and warehouse exceptions.
- **Payments Operations:** Process payment exceptions, chargebacks, and settlement issues.
- **Trust & Payments:** Investigate suspected refund abuse and payment risk.
- **Product Safety:** Assess safety incidents, recalls, and regulatory reporting.
- **Legal & Compliance:** Advise on statutory rights, regulator contacts, and high-risk disputes.
- **Finance Operations:** Reconcile refunds, goodwill spend, and payment-provider exceptions.
- **Policy Owner:** Maintains this policy, training content, and annual review schedule.

9. Related Documents and References

- **CS-WI-006:** Customer Identity Verification in ServiceHub.
- **CS-MAT-003:** No-Return Refund Matrix.
- **CS-STD-009:** Reasonable Contact Standard.
- **RET-PRO-002:** Returns Inspection and Warehouse Disposition Procedure.
- **PAY-PRO-004:** Chargeback and Payment Dispute Procedure.
- **RISK-STD-005:** Product Safety Incident Management Standard.
- **PRIV-STD-001:** Privacy and Records Retention Standard.
- Country-specific consumer terms displayed at checkout and in the customer help centre.

10. Revision History

- **v3.2 — August 2026:** Added marketplace handling, safety escalation within four hours, and revised approval thresholds.
- **v3.1 — February 2026:** Updated return-window language, goodwill controls, and chargeback ownership.
- **v3.0 — September 2025:** Consolidated refund, complaint, and escalation procedures into one policy.